Story 4: What Separates Profitable NYC Airbnbs from the Rest?

DATA 608 · Fall 2026 · Analyst view: helping hosts earn more

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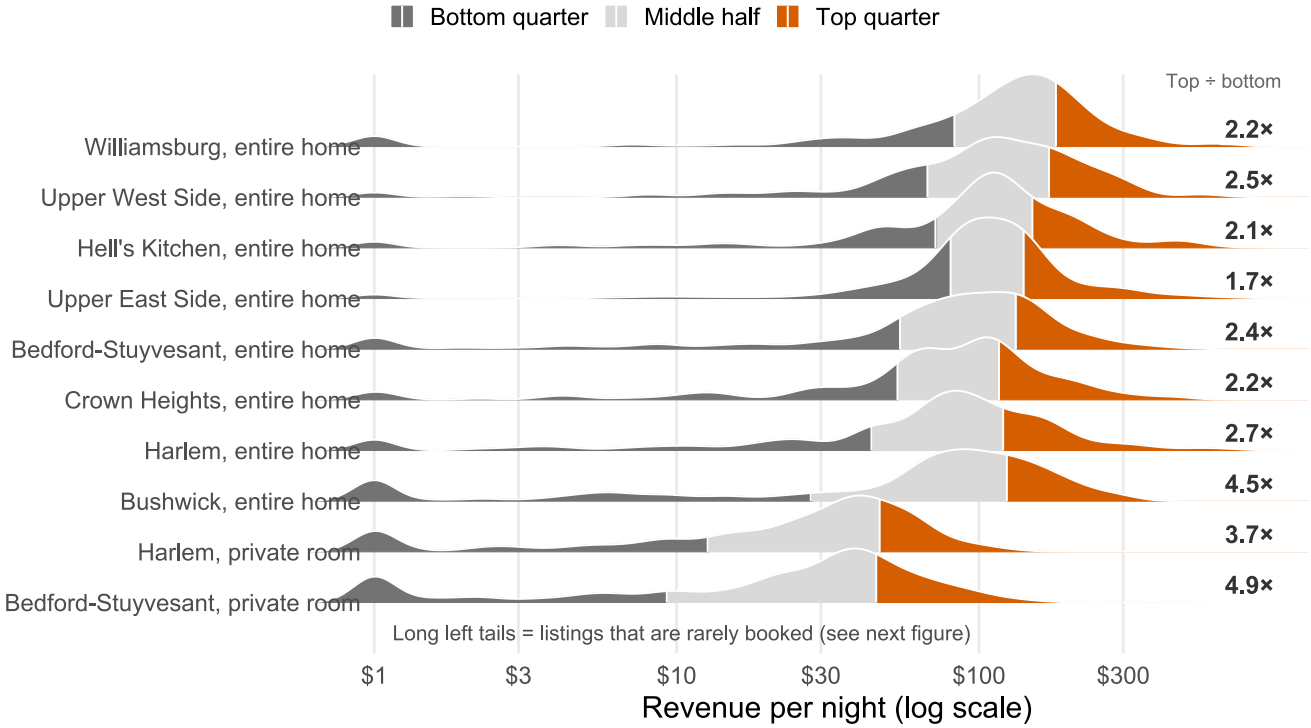
Question: Two listings in the same neighborhood, with the same room type, can earn very different amounts. What separates the high earners from the rest, and what can an underperforming host change?

Short answer: The biggest losses come from listings that have gone quiet. Among active listings, three host habits (superhost status, replying within hours, and ratings of 4.8 or higher) move a listing from below its peers to well above them. Pricing above peers works for entire homes but not for private rooms.

Every comparison is made within a peer group: the same neighborhood, room type and stay length. 78% of listings require stays of 30 nights or more, in line with New York City's short-term rental rules, so those are compared separately from short stays.

Similar listings earn very different amounts: the top quarter makes about 2.5 times the bottom quarter

Distribution of revenue per night (price x occupancy) in the ten largest peer groups, all 30+ night stays. Right column: top-quarter cutoff divided by bottom-quarter cutoff.



Peer group = same neighborhood, room type and stay length. Title ratio = median across all peer groups with 15+ listings. Listings with no booked nights are shown at $1. 353 listings priced above $1,000/night or in shared rooms excluded. Source: Inside Airbnb NYC listings (course dataset).

Figure 1

The first place to look is listings that are not really in business.

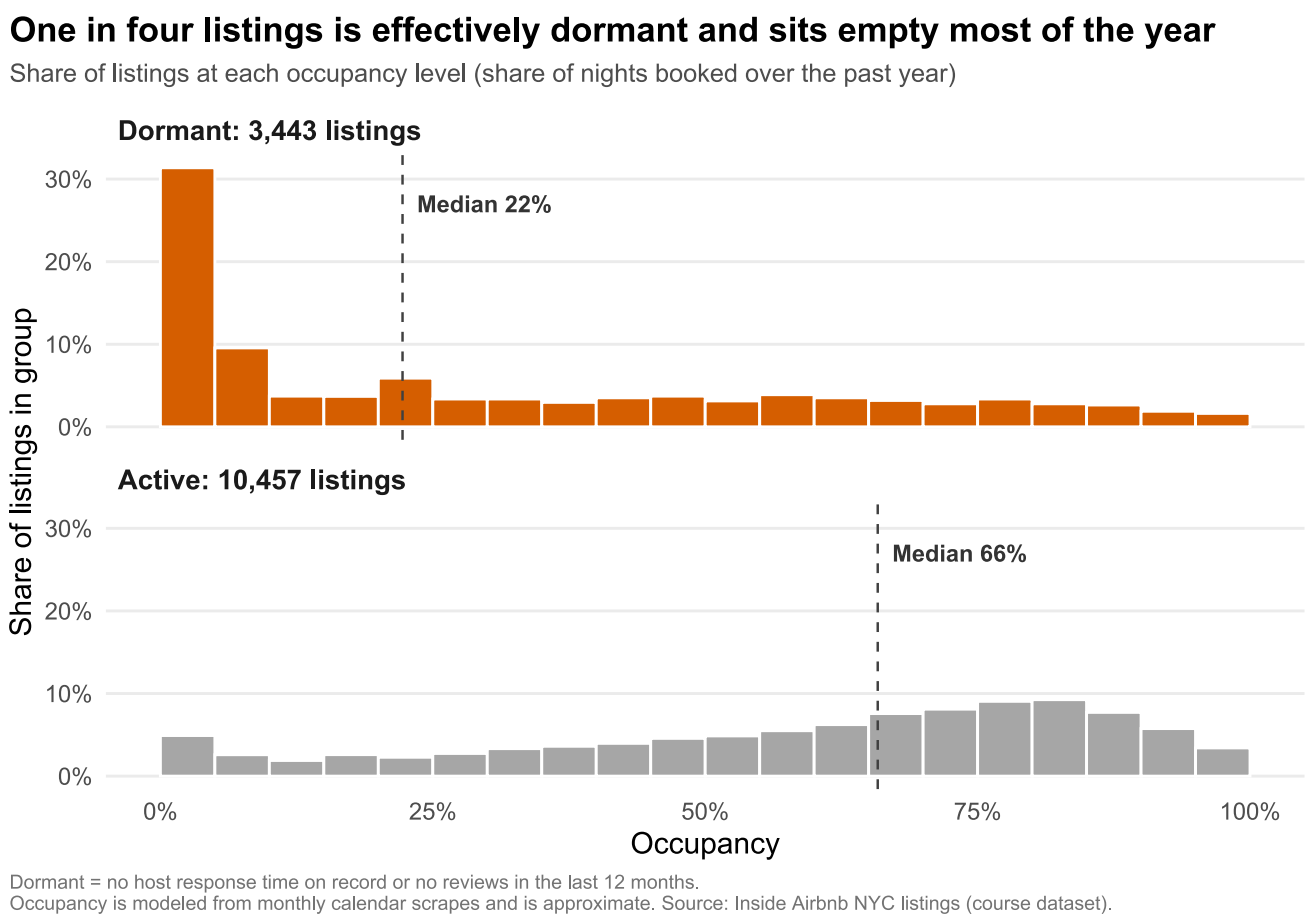


Figure 2

Dormant listings are not spread evenly, which tells an outreach team where to start.

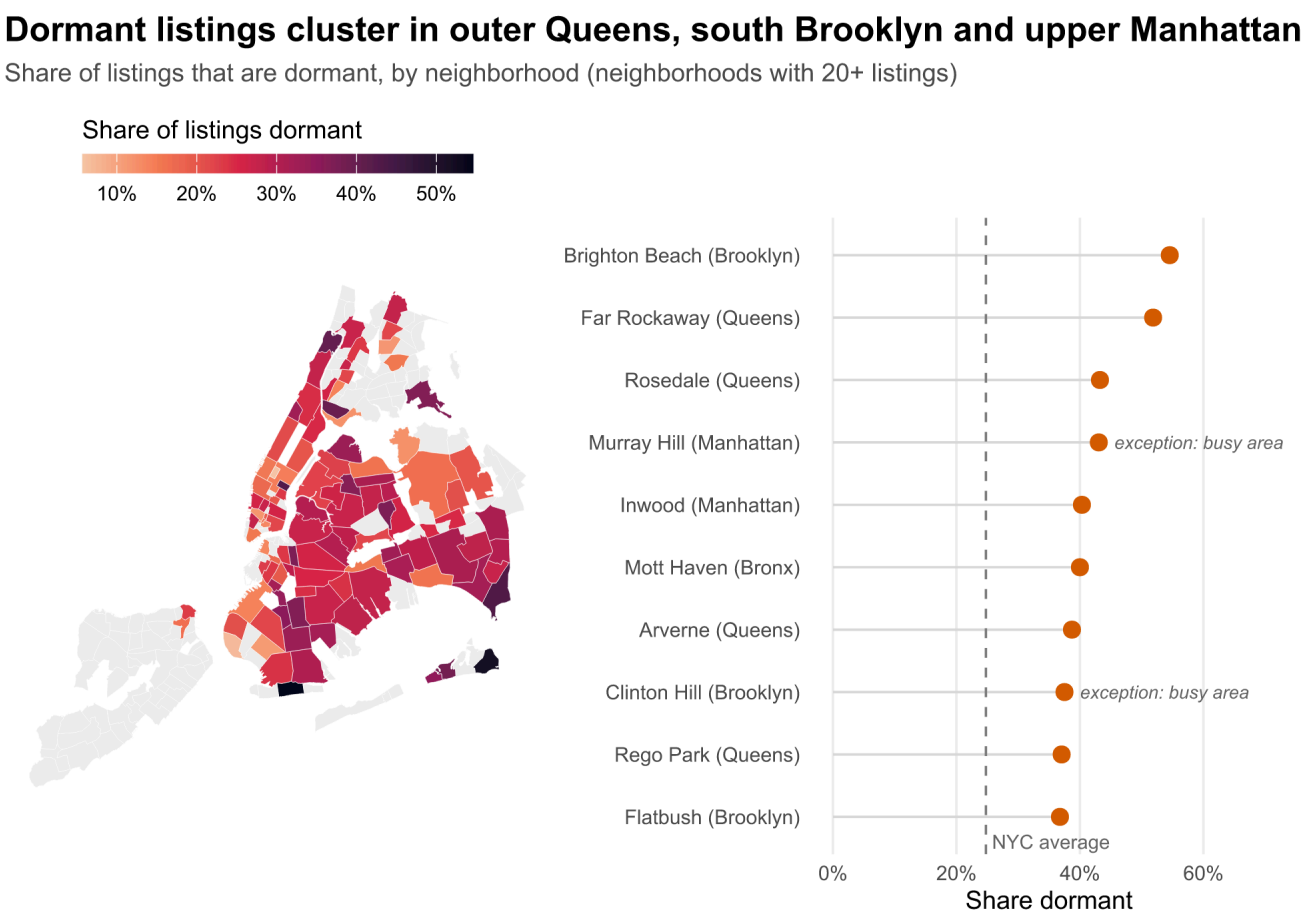


Figure 3

Once a listing is active, three habits a host controls separate the high earners from the rest.

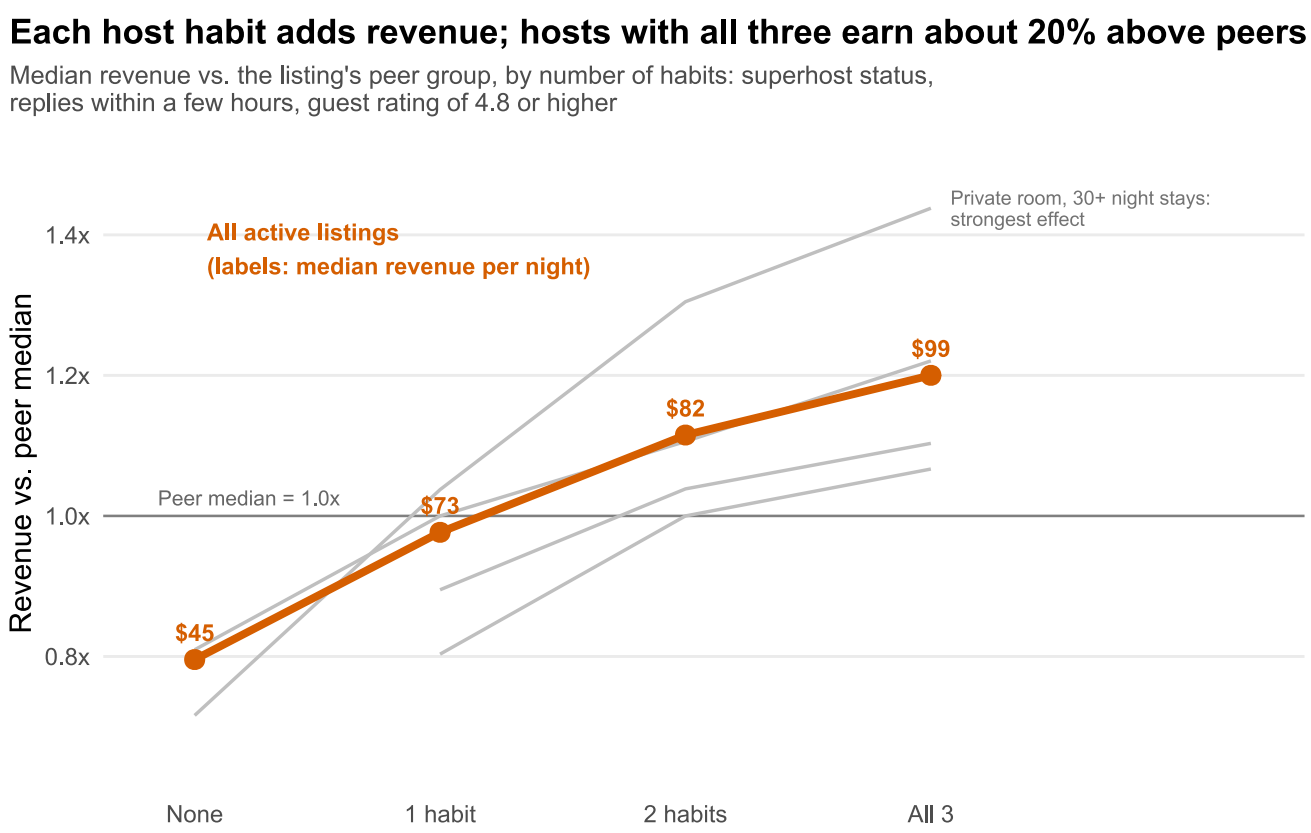


Figure 4

Price is the other lever, and it works differently for whole homes and single rooms.

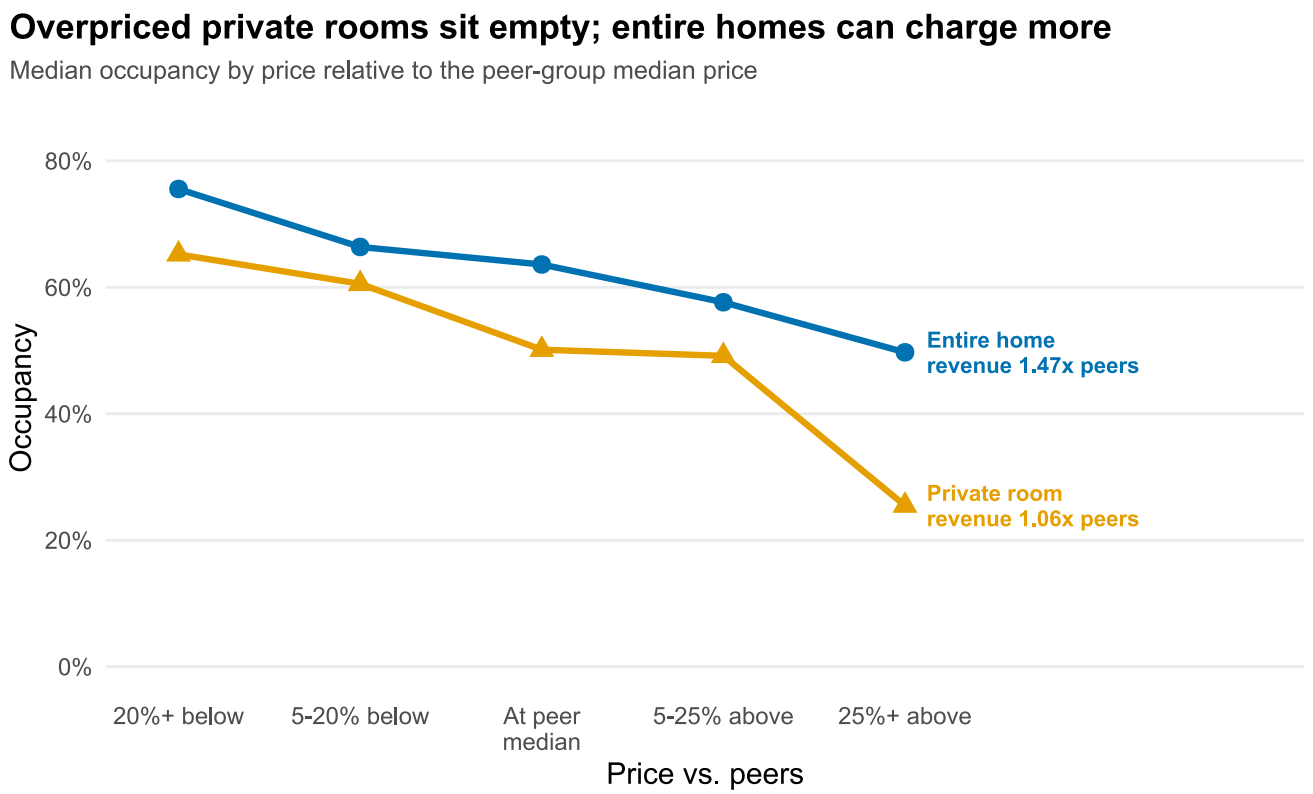


Figure 5

Putting it together: the three levers, ranked by how many listings they reach and how much revenue is at stake.

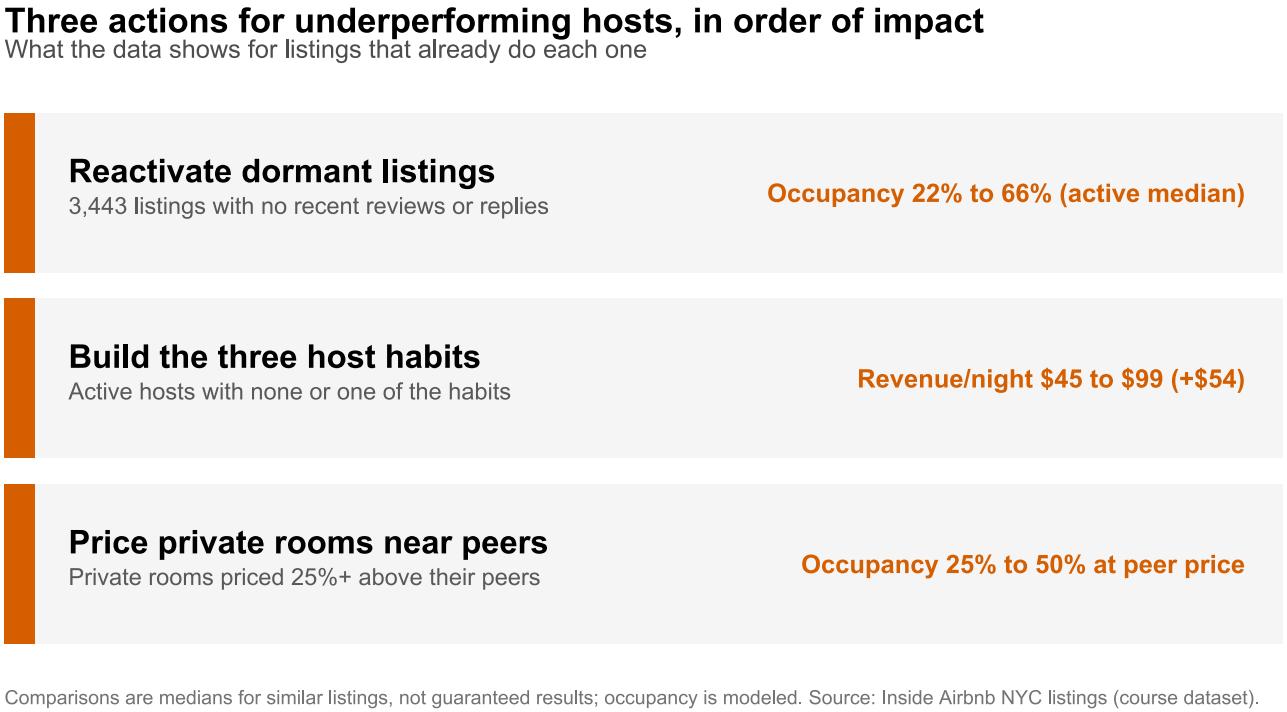


Figure 6

Limitations

- Occupancy is modeled from calendar scrapes, not booking records, so revenue is an estimate.
- These are associations, not proven causes. Busy listings may earn superhost status and good ratings because they are booked often, not only the other way around.
- Superhost status and ratings take time to earn; the fastest lever is response time.